

Sallekha Sutta Study Guide

The Sallekha Sutta (MN 8), opens with the venerable Mahācunda asking the Buddha: “These various views, O Bhante, which arise in the world in connection with the doctrine of self or in connection with the doctrine of the world, for a bhikkhu who is attending to the very starting point [of wholesome dhammas], does the abandoning of these views come to be thus? Does the relinquishing of these views come to be thus?”

To understand venerable Mahācunda's question, we need to understand what these various views are and what the very starting point [of wholesome dhammas] is. These views and their source are explained in the isidatta sutta (SN 41.3) as follows:

"As to the various views that arise in the world, O householder, 'The world is eternal' or 'The world is not eternal'; or 'The world is finite' or 'The world is infinite'; or 'The soul and the body are the same' or 'The soul is one thing, the body is another'; or 'The Tathāgata exists after death,' or 'The Tathāgata does not exist after death,' or 'The Tathāgata both exists and does not exist after death,' or 'The Tathāgata neither exists nor does not exist after death'—these as well as the sixty-two views mentioned in the Brahmajala sutta: when there is self-affirmation view (sakkāyadiṭṭhi), these views come to be; when there is no self-affirmation view, these views do not come to be."

--SN 41.3

The very starting point of wholesome dhammas is defined in the bhikkhu sutta (SN 47.3) as follows:

"Tasmātiha tvaṃ, bhikkhu, ādimeva visodhehi kusalesu dhammesu. Ko cādi kusalānaṃ dhammānaṃ? Sīlañca suvisuddhaṃ, diṭṭhi ca ujukā.

"Therefore, O bhikkhu, you should purify the very starting point of wholesome dhammas. And what is the starting point of wholesome dhammas? Virtue that is well purified and view that is straight.

--SN 47.3

So the venerable Mahācunda's question can be paraphrased as follows:

Of the various views that arise in the world, for a bhikkhu who has purified his virtue to be in conformity with the virtue of the noble ones, and straightened his view to be in conformity to the view of the noble ones, is that enough for such a bhikkhu to abandon these views, to relinquish these views?

The Buddha's answer is:

"These various views, O cunda, which arise in the world in connection with the doctrine of self or in connection with the doctrine of the world, if where these views arise, and where they underlie, and where they roam about, that one sees just this with right wisdom as it has come to be: "Not 'this is mine', not 'this I am', not 'this is my self'", thus the abandoning of these views comes to be, thus the relinquishing of these views comes to be.

--MN 8

But where do these views arise? Where do they underlie? Where do they roam about? From the isidatta sutta, we learned that the source of these views is self-affirmation view (sakkāyadiṭṭhi). When there is self-affirmation view, these views come to be; when there is no self-affirmation view, these views do not come to be."The answer is addressed in the isidatta sutta (SN 41.3) as follows:

"But, venerable sir, how does self-affirmation view comes to be?"

"Here, O householder, the Dhamma-deaf, the puthujjana; the one who does not possess the vision of the noble ones, not an expert, not disciplined in the noble ones' Dhamma; the one who does not possess the vision of true men, not an expert, not disciplined in the true men's Dhamma, recognizes form as self, or self as endowed with form, or form as in self, or self as in form.

He recognizes feeling as self, or self as endowed with feeling, or feeling as in self, or self as in feeling.

He recognizes perception as self, or self as endowed with perception, or perception as in self, or self as in perception.

He recognizes sankharas as self, or self as endowed with sankharas, or sankharas as in self, or self as in sankharas.

He recognizes consciousness as self, or self as endowed with consciousness, or consciousness as in self, or self as in consciousness.

It is in such a way that self-affirmation view comes to be."

"And, venerable sir, how does self-affirmation view not come to be?"

Here, O householder, the Dhamma-hearer, the noble disciple; the one who possesses the vision of the noble ones, an expert, disciplined in the noble ones' Dhamma; the one who possesses the vision of true men, an expert, disciplined in the true men's Dhamma, does not recognize form as self, or self as endowed with form, or form as in self, or self as in form.

He does not recognize feeling as self, or self as endowed with feeling, or feeling as in self, or self as in feeling.

He does not recognize perception as self, or self as endowed with perception, or perception as in self, or self as in perception.

He does not recognize sankharas as self, or self as endowed with sankharas, or sankharas as in self, or self as in sankharas.

He does not recognize consciousness as self, or self as endowed with consciousness, or consciousness as in self, or self as in consciousness.

It is in such a way that self-affirmation view does not come to be."

--SN 41.3

So where these views arise, and where they underlie, and where they roam about, are the pañcupādānakkhandhas, the very foundation of self-affirmation view. With the abandoning of self-affirmation view, these views in connection with the self and in connection with the world do not arise. So how does one abandon the self-affirmation view? This is answered by the Buddha in the sarada sutta (AN 3.94):

Just as, O Bhikkhus, in the autumn, when the sky is clear and cloudless, the sun, rising in the sky, dispels all darkness from space as it shines, radiates and illuminates. So too, when the dust-free, stainless Dhamma-eye arises in the noble disciple, then, together with the arising of vision, the noble disciple abandons

three fetters: self-affirmation view, doubt, and strong hold on virtue and religious duties.

Afterwards, when he departs from two dhammas, longing and ill-will, then, quite secluded from sensual pleasures, secluded from unwholesome dhammas, he enters upon and abides in the happiness and pleasure born of seclusion connected with thinking and pondering, the first jhana. If, O Bhikkhus, that noble disciple should pass away on that occasion, there is no fetter bound by which he might return to this world.

--AN 3.94

So the Buddha's answer amounts to the following:

The pañcupādānakkhandhas are where these views arise, and where they underlie, and where they roam about. The one for whom self-affirmation view is abandoned sees these pañcupādānakkhandhas with right wisdom as they have come to be as: not 'this is mine', not "this I am", not "this is myself." It is for such a one that the abandoning of views comes to be, the relinquishing of views comes to be.

The Buddha further clarifies for the venerable Mahācunda that it is neither by abiding in the jhanas, nor by abiding in the formless (arupa) āyatanas that one abides in effacement. In the noble one's discipline, the jhanas are called pleasant abidings and the formless āyatanas are called peaceful abidings. They are shared in common with puthujjanas and do not lead to effacement. Abiding in the noble measureless samādhi (see samādhi sutta AN 5.27) is the abiding in effacement proper. This abiding is not shared in common with puthujjanas. As explained by the Buddha in the sarada sutta (AN 3.94) and the āneñja sutta (AN 3.116), when a sekha passes away while in a pleasant abiding or in a peaceful abiding, he/she passes away as a non-returner to attain nibbāna in the corresponding abode of being (brahma world or formless realms), whereas if a puthujjana passes away while in a pleasant abiding or peaceful abiding, he/she is headed for deterioration after being reborn in the corresponding abode of being, because he/she is still not free from the sphere of ghosts, the animal womb or the hell realms.

So the Buddha then makes it clear to the venerable Mahācunda that making the breakthrough to the four noble truths is required for the effacement of sakkāyadiṭṭhi to abandon views. Purifying one's virtue to be in conformity with the virtue of the noble ones, and straightening one's view to be in conformity to the view of the noble

ones are necessary but not sufficient for the abandoning of views, for the relinquishing of views.

This virtue that is well purified and view that is straight is none other than the virtue dear to the noble ones and the vision of the Dhamma that a sotāpanna possesses, as described in the anāthapiṇḍika sutta verses (SN 55.26):

yassa saddhā tathāgate,
acalā suppatiṭṭhitā;
sīlañca yassa kalyāṇaṃ,
ariyakantaṃ pasaṃsitaṃ.

“Of whom faith in the Tathagata,
is well established, unshakeable;
of whom there is goodness and virtue,
pleasing and agreeable to the noble ones.

saṅghe pasādo yassatthi,
ujubhūtañca dassanaṃ;
adaḷiddo'ti taṃ āhu,
amoghaṃ tassa jīvitaṃ.

Of whom there is faith in the Sangha,
and view that has come to be straight;
they say that “such a one is not poor,”
that such one's life is not in vain.

tasmā saddhañca sīlañca,
pasādaṃ dhamma dassanaṃ;
anuyuñjetha medhāvī,
saraṃ buddhāna sāsana'nti".

Therefore faith and virtue,
confidence and vision of the Dhamma;
the wise ones devote themselves to,
recollecting the Buddha's instructions.”

--SN 55.26

It is important to know that it is not the case that first one makes the breakthrough to the four noble truths, and then one acquires the purified virtue and the straightened view. In the kosambiya sutta (MN 48), the Buddha makes it clear that one must first bring one's virtue in line with the virtue of a sotāpanna and one's view in line with the view of a sotāpanna. In other words attending to the very starting point of wholesome dhammas is a pre-requisite for making the breakthrough to the four noble truths. It is only when one's virtue is purified and one's view is straight that the breakthrough to the four noble truths is possible.

Now that the venerable Mahācunda understands that for one attending to the very starting point of wholesome dhammas, abiding in effacement takes priority over abiding in the pleasant abidings or the peaceful abidings, the Buddha then instructs him to undertake effacement by abandoning forty four unwholesome dhammas and undertaking their wholesome counterparts.

The forty four wholesome dhammas consist of:

The 10 courses of wholesome actions with non-harming replacing right view:

- (1) non-harming (avihiṃsakā)
- (2) abstaining from killing (pāṇātipātā paṭiviratā)
- (3) abstaining from taking what is not given (adinnādānā)
- (4) celibate (brahmancārī)
- (5) abstaining from speaking falsehood (musavādā paṭiviratā)
- (6) abstaining from divisive speech (pisuṇāya vācāyapaṭiviratā)
- (7) abstaining from harsh speech (pharusāya vācāyapaṭiviratā)
- (8) abstaining from idle chatter (samphappalāpāpaṭiviratā)
- (9) not covetous (anabhijjhālu)
- (10) non-ill-will (abyāpajja cittā)

The ten qualities of the one-beyond-training (asekha):

- (11) right view (sammā diṭṭhi)
- (12) right intention (sammā saṅkappa)
- (13) right speech (sammāvācā)
- (14) right action (sammā kammanta)

- (15) right livelihood (sammā ājīvā)
- (16) right effort (sammā vāyāma)
- (17) right mindfulness (sammā sati)
- (18) right samādhi (sammā samādhi)
- (19) right knowledge (sammā ñāṇa)
- (20) right liberation (sammā vimutti)

The last 3 of the 5 hindrances:

- (21) free from sloth and torpor (vigata thina middhā)
- (22) non-restlessness (anuddhatā)
- (23) crossed over doubt (tiṇṇa vicikicchā)

Entering upon the right way [of conduct] for a samaṇa (cūḷaassapura sutta MN 40):

- (24) non-anger (akkodhanā)
- (25) non-resentful (anupanāhī)
- (26) non-denigrating (amakkhī)
- (27) non-contemptuous (apaḷāsī)
- (28) non-envious (anissukī)
- (29) non-stinginess (amaccharī)
- (30) non-deceitful (amāyāvī)
- (31) non-fraudulent (asaṭhā)

Prerequisites for attaining fruits of anāgāmī in the metta sutta (Snp 1.8) where atthaddha is replaced by its synonym mudu for metrical purposes:

- (32) non-stubborn (atthaddhā/mudu)
- (33) non-arrogant (anatimānī)
- (34) easy to admonish (suvacā)

Foundation for undertaking wholesome dhammas (appamāda sutta SN 3.18):

- (35) noble friends (kalyāṇa mittā)
- (36) vigilant (appamattā)

The seven saddhammas (sekha sutta MN 53):

- (37) faithful (saddhā)
- (38) have moral dignity (hirimanā)
- (39) have moral dread (ottāpī)
- (40) of much learning (bahussutā)
- (41) have aroused energy (āraddha vīriyā)
- (42) established in mindfulness (upaṭṭhitassatī)
- (43) accomplished in wisdom (paññā sampannā)
- (44) not cling to self-views (asandiṭṭhi parāmāsī), not grasping them tenaciously (anādhānaggāhī), easily giving them up (suppaṭinissaggī)

The Buddha then tells the venerable Mahācunda of how helpful the arousal of the mind towards wholesome thoughts is, and instructs him to arouse his mind accordingly with the same forty four wholesome dhammas.

Now let's analyze the sequence of these forty four wholesome dhammas with respect to the Buddha's gradual path, gradual practice and gradual progress.

In the appamāda sutta (SN 3.18), the Buddha confirms to King Pasenadi that the dhamma is well-proclaimed by him, but [for] one of noble friend, of noble companion, of noble comrad, not of evil friend, not of evil companion, not of evil comrad. He tells the king that the entire life of purity depends on noble friendship and gives himself as an example of how that is so, since owing to him as a noble friend, because of him as a noble friend, beings liable to birth are freed from birth; beings liable to old age are freed from old age; beings liable to sickness are freed from sickness; beings liable to death are freed from death; beings liable to sorrow, lamentation, physical suffering, mental suffering and despair are freed from sorrow, lamentation, physical suffering, mental suffering and despair. He then instructs the king thus:

tasmātiha te mahārāja evaṃ sikkhitabbaṃ: kalyāṇamitto bhavissāmi
kalyāṇasahāyo kalyāṇasampavaṅko'ti. evaṃ hi te mahārāja sikkhitabbaṃ.
kalyāṇamittassa te mahārāja kalyāṇasahāyassa kalyāṇasampavaṅkassa ayaṃ
eko dhammo upanissāya vihātabbo appamādo.

Therefore, for you, O great king, it should be trained thus: "I will be of noble friend, noble companion, noble comrad." Thus indeed for you, O great king, should it be trained. For you, O great king, [being] of noble friend, of noble companion, of noble comrad, you should dwell depending on this one thing alone,

that is vigilance in wholesome dhammas.

--SN 3.18

So items (35) noble friendship and (36) being vigilant are the two supports for one who is attending to the very starting point of wholesome dhammas. In the *dīghajāṇu sutta* (AN 8.54), the Buddha defines *kalyāṇamitta* and describes the practice of virtue purification and view straightening:

And what is noble friendship? Here, in whatever village or town a clansman lives, he associates with householders or their sons—whether young but fulfilled in virtue, or old but fulfilled in virtue—who are accomplished in faith, virtuous behavior, generosity, and wisdom [at least a *sotāpanna*]; he converses with them and engages in discussions with them. Insofar as they are accomplished in faith, he emulates them with respect to their accomplishment in faith; insofar as they are accomplished in virtuous behavior, he emulates them with respect to their accomplishment in virtuous behavior; insofar as they are accomplished in generosity, he emulates them with respect to their accomplishment in generosity; insofar as they are accomplished in wisdom, he emulates them with respect to their accomplishment in wisdom. This is called noble friendship.

--AN 8.54 (Ven. Bodhi's translation with slight modifications)

And so the practice of virtue purification consists of one discussing virtue with those accomplished in virtue and emulating them with respect to their virtue accordingly until one's virtue conforms to theirs. Likewise, the practice of view straightening consists of one discussing faith, generosity and wisdom with those accomplished in faith, generosity and wisdom and emulating them with respect to their faith, generosity and wisdom accordingly until one's faith, generosity and wisdom conforms to theirs.

Given that nowadays true *kalyāṇamittas* are very rare, if one does not have access to a *kalyāṇamitta*, then one need to rely on *saddhamma* studies and discussions to understand the virtue and view of the noble ones and continuously emulate them with vigilance until one's virtue and view come in conformity with that of the noble ones. If one succeeds at this, then one has fulfilled the very starting point of wholesome dhammas.

With virtue that is purified and view that has become straight as foundation, if based on one's faith in the Buddha's awakening, one is resolved on realizing the Buddha's

teachings on impermanence to the extent that the five faculties have come to be (see kīṭāgiri sutta MN 70), the Buddha declares of such a one in the khandhā sutta (SN 25.10):

"This is called a faith follower (saddhanusari), one who has entered upon the fixed course of rightness, who has entered the plane of the true man, who has transcended the plane of the puthujjana. He is unable to do that deed which having done such a deed, he would be reborn in hell, or the animal womb or the sphere of ghost. He is definately incapable of passing away as long as he has not realized the fruit of stream entry."

--SN 25.10

With virtue that is purified and view that has become straight as foundation, if one submits to the Buddha's teaching on impermanence based on a measure of understanding with wisdom, and one is resolved on realizing these teachings to the extent that the five faculties have come to be (see kīṭāgiri sutta MN 70), the Buddha declares of such a one in the khandhā sutta (SN 25.10):

"This is called a dhamma follower (dhammanusari), one who has entered upon the fixed course of rightness, who has entered the plane of the true man, who has transcended the plane of the puthujjana. He is unable to do that deed which having done such a deed, he would be reborn in hell, or the animal womb, or the sphere of ghost. He is definately incapable of passing away as long as he has not realized the fruit of stream entry."

--SN 25.10

Both the saddhānusārī and dhammānusārī have entered upon the path to the realization of the fruit of stream-entry and are endowed with items (1)-(10).

By relying on the five faculties they have acquired, if they strive for the breakthrough to the four noble truths with vigilance and come to know and see the Buddha's teaching on impermanence, the Buddha declares of such a one in the khandhā sutta (SN 25.10):

"This is called a stream enterer (sotāpanna), not subject to the woeful plane, on a fixed course, destined for supreme awakening."

--SN 25.10

The sotāpanna possesses the ten qualities of one-beyond-training, items (11)-(20) as declared in the anāthapiṇḍikovāda sutta (MN 143).

The sotāpanna has effaced three of the five lower fetters, namely, self-affirmation view, doubt, and clinging to virtue and religious duties. His next major task is to efface the remaining two of the five lower fetters, namely, sensual lust and ill-will. These last two lower fetters, together with items (21)-(23) are called the five hindrances (pañca nīvaraṇa). If that sotāpanna is a bhikkhu or bhikkhunī, then he or she becomes worthy of the designation "ascetic" (samaṇa or samaṇī) as the Buddha declares in the cūlasīhanāda sutta (MN 11) that it is "only here [in the Buddha's teachings] is there a samaṇa, here a second samaṇa, here a third samaṇa, here a fourth samaṇa, other insignificant teachings of outsiders are empty of samaṇas."

Now with worthiness of the "samaṇa" designation comes the responsibility to remove the stains of a samaṇa (samaṇamalānaṃ), defects of a samaṇa (samaṇadosānaṃ), dregs of a samaṇa (samaṇakasaṭṭānaṃ) as instructed in the cūla assapura sutta (MN 40). The antidote to these stains of a samaṇa, defects of a samaṇa, dregs of a samaṇa are given in items (24)-(31).

Further pre-requisites for attaining fruits of non-returner is given in the metta sutta (Snp 1.8) where atthaddha is replaced by its synonym, mudu, for metrical purposes. These are items

(32)-(34).

So when the sotāpanna succeeds in abandoning the five hindrances and removing the stains of a samaṇa, defects of a samaṇa, dregs of a samaṇa, and fulfilling the pre-requisites for attaining fruits of non-returner, he/she becomes a non-returner (anāgāmī).

Since we have already covered items (35)-(36), the next set of items are called the seven saddhammas of a sekha who has entered upon the path (37)-(43) (see sekha sutta MN 53). When an anāgāmī is endowed with these seven saddhammas and can obtain at will without trouble or difficulty the four jhanas that constitute the higher mind (adhicitta) and provide a pleasant abiding here and now, he is called a sekha who has entered upon the path [to arahantship].

Finally for item (44), having given up personal views, one has to relinquish all views, including the very purified view of the Dhamma that enabled one to attain anāgāmī. As explained in the mahātaṇhāsankhayasutta (MN 38), regarding the simile of the raft:

"Bhikkhus, this view thus cleansed, thus purified, if you do not adhere to it, cherish it, treasure it, and appropriate it, would you then understand the Dhamma as taught by me to be similar to a raft, being for the purpose of crossing over, not for the purpose of holding onto?"

"Yes, Bhante."

--MN 38

Thus, if he is able to let go the purified view of the Dhamma, he attains complete nibbāna through non-holding (anupādāparinibbāna).

And so we see that this list of forty four wholesome dhammas fit nicely into the Buddha's gradual path, gradual practice, gradual progress.

The Buddha then explains the gradual progress of effacement with several similes. First, one fulfills the starting point of wholesome dhammas by straightening one's view and purifying one's virtue to enter the noble path (saddhānusārī or dhammānusārī). Then with accomplishment in virtue (sotāpannā), one undertakes the forty four wholesome dhammas to avoid their unwholesome counterparts. The simile of the even path or ford that is used to avoid an uneven path or ford helps illustrate this. This is adhisīla.

Then by further undertaking of these forty four wholesome dhammas, when one is able to enter the jhanas or the formless ayatanas, then one has transcended the forty four unwholesome counterparts. Here the simile of all wholesome dhammas leading upwards (uparibhāgāya) is used. This is adhicitta.

Finally, by further undertaking of these forty four wholesome dhammas, when one is able to enter and abide in a cessation attainment (appamāṇa samādhi), then one brings all forty four wholesome dhammas and their forty four unwholesome counterparts to cessation, extinction. The Buddha illustrates this with the famous simile of one sinking in the mud. He explains that it is not possible for one sinking in the mud to help another who is sinking in the mud. Likewise in his teachings, it is not

possible that one who is himself untamed, undisciplined, not attained nibbāna, can tame another, discipline another, or help another to attain nibbāna; but it is possible that one who is himself tamed, disciplined, attained nibbāna, can tame another, discipline another, and help another attain nibbana. This is adhipaññā.

The Buddha ends the discourse with the admonition to venerable Mahācunda that he has done his part as any compassionate teacher would do for his students out of compassion. It is venerable Mahācunda's turn to act upon his instructions by going into seclusion to meditate without delay to realize his teachings. For a disciple wishing to reciprocate the Teacher's compassion, it is proper that he acts upon the Teacher's instructions, proper that he acts upon the Teacher's advice.

** MN 8. sallekha sutta **

Thus was heard by me. At one time the Auspicious One was dwelling at Sāvatti in Jeta's Grove, Anathapindika's Park. Then in the evening time, the venerable Mahācunda, having emerged from seclusion, he visited with the Auspicious One. Upon arrival, he bowed down to the Auspicious One and sat down to one side. Having sat down to one side, the venerable Mahacunda said this to the Auspicious One:

“These various views, O Bhante, which arise in the world in connection with the doctrine of self or in connection with the doctrine of the world, for a bhikkhu who is attending to the very starting point [of wholesome dhammas], does the abandoning of these views come to be thus? Does the relinquishing of these views come to be thus?”

“These various views, O Cunda, which arise in the world in connection with the doctrine of self or in connection with the doctrine of the world, if where these views arise, and where they underlie, and where they roam about, that one sees just this with right wisdom as it has come to be: Not ‘this is mine’, not ‘this I am’, not ‘this is my self’, thus the abandoning of these views comes to be, thus the relinquishing of these views comes to be.

(The Four Pleasant Abidings)

“It is possible here, O Cunda, that “quite secluded from sense-desires, secluded from unwholesome dhammas, some bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the rapture and pleasure born of seclusion connected with thinking and pondering, the first jhana. It occurs to him thus: ‘I am abiding in effacement.’ But these attainments, O Cunda, are not called ‘effacement’ in the Noble One’s Discipline: these are called ‘pleasant abidings here and now’ in the Noble One’s Discipline.

“It is possible here, O Cunda, that from the subsiding of thinking and pondering, with the internal tranquilization and unification of mind, without thinking, without pondering, some bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the rapture and pleasure born of samadhi, the second jhana. It occurs to him thus: ‘I am abiding in effacement.’ But these attainments, O Cunda, are not called ‘effacement’ in the Noble One’s Discipline: these are called ‘pleasant abidings here and now’ in the Noble One’s Discipline.

“It is possible here, O Cunda, that with the fading away of rapture, some bhikkhu, dwelling mindful and contemplative, looks on with equanimity as he experiences pleasure in the body, of which the Noble Ones say: “The mindful one is he who dwells in pleasure with equanimity.” It occurs to him thus: ‘I am abiding in effacement.’ But these attainments, O Cunda, are not called ‘effacement’ in the Noble One’s Discipline: these are called ‘pleasant abidings here and now’ in the Noble One’s Discipline.

“It is possible here, O Cunda, that with the abandoning of [physical] pleasure and pain, from the extinction of former mental pleasure and mental pain, some bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the utter purity of mindfulness and equanimity, without pain, without pleasure, the fourth jhana. It occurs to him thus: ‘I am abiding in effacement.’ But these attainments, O Cunda, are not called

‘effacement’ in the Noble One’s Discipline: these are called ‘pleasant abidings here and now’ in the Noble One’s Discipline.

(The Four Peaceful Abidings)

“It is possible here, O Cunda, that from the complete surmounting of perceptions of form, from the extinguishing of perceptions of resistance, from non-attention to perceptions of diversity, “space becomes infinite,” some bhikkhu enters and dwells in the domain of infinite space. It occurs to him thus: ‘I am abiding in effacement.’ But these attainments, O Cunda, are not called ‘effacement’ in the Noble One’s Discipline: these are called ‘peaceful abidings’ here and now in the Noble One’s Discipline.

“It is possible here, O Cunda, that having completely surmounted the domain of infinite space, “consciousness becomes infinite,” some bhikkhu enters and dwells in the domain of infinite consciousness. It occurs to him thus: ‘I am abiding in effacement.’ But these attainments, O Cunda, are not called ‘effacement’ in the Noble One’s Discipline: these are called ‘peaceful abidings’ here and now in the Noble One’s Discipline.

“It is possible here, O Cunda, that having completely surmounted the domain of infinite consciousness, “there is nothing,” some bhikkhu enters and dwells in the domain of nothingness. It occurs to him thus: ‘I am abiding in effacement.’ But these attainments, O Cunda, are not called ‘effacement’ in the Noble One’s Discipline: these are called ‘peaceful abidings’ here and now in the Noble One’s Discipline.

“It is possible here, O Cunda, that having completely surmounted the domain of nothingness, some bhikkhu enters and dwells in the domain of neither perception nor non-perception. It occurs to him thus: ‘I am abiding in effacement.’ But these attainments, O Cunda, are not called ‘effacement’ in the Noble One’s Discipline: these are called ‘peaceful abidings’ here and now in the Noble One’s Discipline.

(Effacement)

“Now here, O Cunda, effacement is to be done by you:

(1) ‘Others will be harmful; we will not be harmful here’: is effacement to be done.

(2) ‘Others will kill living beings; we will abstain from killing living beings here’: is effacement to be done.

(3) ‘Others will take what is not given; we will abstain from taking what is not given here’: is effacement to be done.

(4) ‘Others will be uncelibate; we will be celibate here’: is effacement to be done.

(5) ‘Others will speak falsehood; we will abstain from false speech here’: is effacement to be done.

(6) ‘Others will speak maliciously; we will abstain from malicious speech here’: is effacement to be done.

(7) ‘Others will speak harshly; we will abstain from harsh speech here’: is effacement to be done.

(8) ‘Others will gossip; we will abstain from gossip here’: is effacement to be done.

(9) ‘Others will be covetous; we will be uncovetous here’: is effacement to be done.

(10) ‘Others will have ill will; we will be without ill will here’: is effacement to be done.

(11) ‘Others will be of wrong view; we will be of right view here’:

is effacement to be done.

(12) 'Others will be of wrong intention; we will be of right intention here': is effacement to be done.

(13) 'Others will be of wrong speech; we will be of right speech here': is effacement to be done.

(14) 'Others will be of wrong action; we will be of right action here': is effacement to be done.

(15) 'Others will be of wrong livelihood; we will be of right livelihood here': is effacement to be done.

(16) 'Others will be of wrong effort; we will be of right effort here': is effacement to be done.

(17) 'Others will be of wrong mindfulness; we will be of right mindfulness here': is effacement to be done.

(18) 'Others will be of wrong samadhi; we will be of right samadhi here': is effacement to be done.

(19) 'Others will be of wrong knowledge; we will be of right knowledge here': is effacement to be done.

(20) 'Others will be of wrong liberation; we will be of right liberation here': is effacement to be done.

(21) 'Others will be overcome by sloth and torpor; we will be free from sloth and torpor here': is effacement to be done.

(22) 'Others will be restless; we will not be restless here': is effacement to be done.

(23) 'Others will be doubters; we will cross over doubt here': is

effacement to be done.

(24) 'Others will be angry; we will not be angry here': is effacement to be done.

(25) 'Others will be resentful; we will not be resentful here': is effacement to be done.

(26) 'Others will be denigrating; we will not be denigrating here': is effacement to be done.

(27) 'Others will be contemptuous; we will not be contemptuous here': is effacement to be done.

(28) 'Others will be envious; we will not be envious here': is effacement to be done.

(29) 'Others will be stingy; we will not be stingy here': is effacement to be done.

(30) 'Others will be deceitful; we will not be deceitful here': is effacement to be done.

(31) 'Others will be fraudulent; we will not be fraudulent here': is effacement to be done.

(32) 'Others will be obstinate; we will not be obstinate here': is effacement to be done.

(33) 'Others will be arrogant; we will not be arrogant here': is effacement to be done.

(34) 'Others will be difficult to admonish; we will be easy to admonish here': is effacement to be done.

(35) 'Others will have bad friends; we will have good friends here':

is effacement to be done.

(36) 'Others will be negligent; we will be vigilant here': is effacement to be done.

(37) 'Others will lack faith; we will possess faith here': is effacement to be done.

(38) 'Others will lack moral dignity; we will possess moral dignity here': is effacement to be done.

(39) 'Others will lack moral dread; we will possess moral dread here': is effacement to be done.

(40) 'Others will be of little learning; we will be of great learning here': is effacement to be done.

(41) 'Others will be lazy; we will be energetic here': is effacement to be done.

(42) 'Others will be unmindful; we will be established in mindfulness here': is effacement to be done.

(43) 'Others will lack wisdom; we will possess wisdom here': is effacement to be done.

(44) 'Others will adhere to their own views, hold on to them tenaciously, and relinquish them with difficulty; we will not adhere to our own views or hold on to them tenaciously, but will relinquish them easily': is effacement to be done.

(Arousal of Mind)

"O Cunda, I say that even the arousal of mind towards wholesome dhammas is of great benefit, so what should be said of bodily and verbal acts conforming to such a state of mind? Therefore, O Cunda:

(1) 'Others will be harmful; we will not be harmful here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(2) 'Others will kill living beings; we will abstain from killing living beings here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(3) 'Others will take what is not given; we will abstain from taking what is not given here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(4) 'Others will be uncelibate; we will be celibate here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(5) 'Others will speak falsehood; we will abstain from false speech here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(6) 'Others will speak maliciously; we will abstain from malicious speech here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(7) 'Others will speak harshly; we will abstain from harsh speech here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(8) 'Others will gossip; we will abstain from gossip here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(9) 'Others will be covetous; we will be uncovetous here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(10) 'Others will have ill will; we will be without ill will here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(11) 'Others will be of wrong view; we will be of right view here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(12) 'Others will be of wrong intention; we will be of right intention here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(13) 'Others will be of wrong speech; we will be of right speech here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(14) 'Others will be of wrong action; we will be of right action here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(15) 'Others will be of wrong livelihood; we will be of right livelihood here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(16) 'Others will be of wrong effort; we will be of right effort here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(17) 'Others will be of wrong mindfulness; we will be of right mindfulness here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(18) 'Others will be of wrong samadhi; we will be of right samadhi here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(19) 'Others will be of wrong knowledge; we will be of right knowledge here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(20) 'Others will be of wrong liberation; we will be of right liberation here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(21) 'Others will be overcome by sloth and torpor; we will be free from sloth and torpor here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(22) 'Others will be restless; we will not be restless here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(23) 'Others will be doubters; we will cross over doubt here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(24) 'Others will be angry; we will not be angry here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(25) 'Others will be resentful; we will not be resentful here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(26) 'Others will be denigrating; we will not be denigrating here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(27) 'Others will be contemptuous; we will not be contemptuous here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(28) 'Others will be envious; we will not be envious here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(29) 'Others will be stingy; we will not be stingy here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(30) 'Others will be deceitful; we will not be deceitful here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(31) 'Others will be fraudulent; we will not be fraudulent here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(32) 'Others will be obstinate; we will not be obstinate here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(33) 'Others will be arrogant; we will not be arrogant here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(34) 'Others will be difficult to admonish; we will be easy to admonish here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(35) 'Others will have bad friends; we will have good friends here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(36) 'Others will be negligent; we will be vigilant here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(37) 'Others will lack faith; we will possess faith here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(38) 'Others will lack moral dignity; we will possess moral dignity here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(39) 'Others will lack moral dread; we will possess moral dread here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(40) 'Others will be of little learning; we will be of great learning here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(41) 'Others will be lazy; we will be energetic here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(42) 'Others will be unmindful; we will be established in mindfulness here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(43) 'Others will lack wisdom; we will possess wisdom here': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(44) 'Others will adhere to their own views, hold on to them tenaciously, and relinquish them with difficulty; we will not adhere to our own views or hold on to them tenaciously, but will relinquish them easily': the mind should be aroused [thus].

(Avoidance)

"O Cunda, suppose there were an uneven path and another even path by which to avoid it; and suppose there were an uneven ford and another even ford by which to avoid it. So too:

(1) One given to harmfulness has harmlessness by which to avoid it.

(2) One given to killing living beings has abstention from killing

living beings by which to avoid it.

(3) One given to taking what is not given has abstention from taking what is not given by which to avoid it.

(4) One given to uncelibacy has celibacy by which to avoid it.

(5) One given to false speech has abstention from false speech by which to avoid it.

(6) One given to malicious speech has abstention from malicious speech by which to avoid it.

(7) One given to harsh speech has abstention from harsh speech by which to avoid it.

(8) One given to gossip has abstention from gossip by which to avoid it.

(9) One given to covetousness has uncovetousness by which to avoid it.

(10) One given to ill will has non-ill will by which to avoid it.

(11) One given to wrong view has right view by which to avoid it.

(12) One given to wrong intention has right intention by which to avoid it.

(13) One given to wrong speech has right speech by which to avoid it.

(14) One given to wrong action has right action by which to avoid it.

(15) One given to wrong livelihood has right livelihood by which to

avoid it.

(16) One given to wrong effort has right effort by which to avoid it.

(17) One given to wrong mindfulness has right mindfulness by which to avoid it.

(18) One given to wrong samadhi has right samadhi by which to avoid it.

(19) One given to wrong knowledge has right knowledge by which to avoid it.

(20) One given to wrong liberation has right liberation by which to avoid it.

(21) One given to sloth and torpor has freedom from sloth and torpor by which to avoid it.

(22) One given to restlessness has non-restlessness by which to avoid it.

(23) One given to doubt has crossing over doubt by which to avoid it.

(24) One given to anger has non-anger by which to avoid it.

(25) One given to resentment has non-resentment by which to avoid it.

(26) One given to denigrating has non-denigrating by which to avoid it.

(27) One given to contempt has non-contempt by which to avoid it.

(28) One given to envy has non-envy by which to avoid it.

(29) One given to stinginess has non-stinginess by which to avoid it.

(30) One given to deceit has non-deceit by which to avoid it.

(31) One given to fraud has non-fraud by which to avoid it.

(32) One given to obstinacy has non-obstinacy by which to avoid it.

(33) One given to arrogance has non-arrogance by which to avoid it.

(34) One given to being difficult to admonish has being easy to admonish by which to avoid it.

(35) One given to making bad friends has making good friends by which to avoid it.

(36) One given to negligence has vigilance by which to avoid it.

(37) One given to faithlessness has faith by which to avoid it.

(38) One given to lack of moral dignity has moral dignity by which to avoid it.

(39) One given to lack of moral dread has moral dread by which to avoid it.

(40) One given to little learning has great learning by which to avoid it.

(41) One given to laziness has the arousal of energy by which to avoid it.

(42) One given to unmindfulness has the establishment of mindfulness

by which to avoid it.

(43) One given to lack of wisdom has the acquisition of wisdom by which to avoid it.

(44) One given to adhering to his own views, holding on to them tenaciously and relinquishing them with difficulty, has non-adherence to his own views, not holding on to them tenaciously and relinquishing them easily, by which to avoid it.

(The Way Leading Upwards)

“O Cunda, just as all unwholesome dhammas lead downwards and all wholesome dhammas lead upwards, so too:

(1) One given to harmfulness has harmlessness to lead him upwards.

(2) One given to killing living beings has abstention from killing living beings to lead him upwards.

(3) One given to taking what is not given has abstention from taking what is not given to lead him upwards.

(4) One given to uncelibacy has celibacy to lead him upwards.

(5) One given to false speech has abstention from false speech to lead him upwards.

(6) One given to malicious speech has abstention from malicious speech to lead him upwards.

(7) One given to harsh speech has abstention from harsh speech to lead him upwards.

(8) One given to gossip has abstention from gossip to lead him upwards.

(9) One given to covetousness has uncovetousness to lead him upwards.

(10) One given to ill will has non-ill will to lead him upwards.

(11) One given to wrong view has right view to lead him upwards.

(12) One given to wrong intention has right intention to lead him upwards.

(13) One given to wrong speech has right speech to lead him upwards.

(14) One given to wrong action has right action to lead him upwards.

(15) One given to wrong livelihood has right livelihood to lead him upwards.

(16) One given to wrong effort has right effort to lead him upwards.

(17) One given to wrong mindfulness has right mindfulness to lead him upwards.

(18) One given to wrong samadhi has right samadhi to lead him upwards.

(19) One given to wrong knowledge has right knowledge to lead him upwards.

(20) One given to wrong liberation has right liberation to lead him upwards.

(21) One given to sloth and torpor has freedom from sloth and torpor to lead him upwards.

(22) One given to restlessness has non-restlessness to lead him

upwards.

(23) One given to doubt has crossing over doubt to lead him upwards.

(24) One given to anger has non-anger to lead him upwards.

(25) One given to resentment has non-resentment to lead him upwards.

(26) One given to denigrating has non-denigrating to lead him upwards.

(27) One given to contempt has non-contempt to lead him upwards.

(28) One given to envy has non-envy to lead him upwards.

(29) One given to stinginess has non-stinginess to lead him upwards.

(30) One given to deceit has non-deceit to lead him upwards.

(31) One given to fraud has non-fraud to lead him upwards.

(32) One given to obstinacy has non-obstinacy to lead him upwards.

(33) One given to arrogance has non-arrogance to lead him upwards.

(34) One given to being difficult to admonish has being easy to admonish to lead him upwards.

(35) One given to making bad friends has making good friends to lead him upwards.

(36) One given to negligence has vigilance to lead him upwards.

(37) One given to faithlessness has faith to lead him upwards.

(38) One given to lack of moral dignity has moral dignity to lead

him upwards.

(39) One given to lack of moral dread has moral dread to lead him upwards.

(40) One given to little learning has great learning to lead him upwards.

(41) One given to laziness has the arousal of energy to lead him upwards.

(42) One given to unmindfulness has the establishment of mindfulness to lead him upwards.

(43) One given to lack of wisdom has the acquisition of wisdom to lead him upwards.

(44) One given to adhering to his own views, holding on to them tenaciously and relinquishing them with difficulty, has non-adherence to his own views, not holding on to them tenaciously and relinquishing them easily, to lead him upwards.

(The Way of Extinguishing)

Indeed, O Cunda, that one who is sunk in a mud himself will pull out another who is sunk in a mud, this possibility is not to be found. Indeed, O Cunda, that one who is not sunk in a mud himself will pull out another who is sunk in a mud, this possibility is to be found. Indeed, O Cunda, that one who is not tamed, not trained, not fully extinguished himself will tame, train, [help to] fully extinguish another, this possibility is not to be found. Indeed, O Cunda, that one who is tamed, trained, fully extinguished himself will tame, train, [help to] fully extinguish another, this possibility is to be found. So too:

(1) One given to harmfulness has harmlessness by which to extinguish

it.

(2) One given to killing living beings has abstention from killing living beings by which to extinguish it.

(3) One given to taking what is not given has abstention from taking what is not given by which to extinguish it.

(4) One given to uncelibacy has celibacy by which to extinguish it.

(5) One given to false speech has abstention from false speech by which to extinguish it.

(6) One given to malicious speech has abstention from malicious speech by which to extinguish it.

(7) One given to harsh speech has abstention from harsh speech by which to extinguish it.

(8) One given to gossip has abstention from gossip by which to extinguish it.

(9) One given to covetousness has uncovetousness by which to extinguish it.

(10) One given to ill will has non-ill will by which to extinguish it.

(11) One given to wrong view has right view by which to extinguish it.

(12) One given to wrong intention has right intention by which to extinguish it.

(13) One given to wrong speech has right speech by which to extinguish it.

(14) One given to wrong action has right action by which to extinguish it.

(15) One given to wrong livelihood has right livelihood by which to extinguish it.

(16) One given to wrong effort has right effort by which to extinguish it.

(17) One given to wrong mindfulness has right mindfulness by which to extinguish it.

(18) One given to wrong samadhi has right samadhi by which to extinguish it.

(19) One given to wrong knowledge has right knowledge by which to extinguish it.

(20) One given to wrong liberation has right liberation by which to extinguish it.

(21) One given to sloth and torpor has freedom from sloth and torpor by which to extinguish it.

(22) One given to restlessness has non-restlessness by which to extinguish it.

(23) One given to doubt has crossing over doubt by which to extinguish it.

(24) One given to anger has non-anger by which to extinguish it.

(25) One given to resentment has non-resentment by which to extinguish it.

(26) One given to denigrating has non-denigrating by which to extinguish it.

(27) One given to contempt has non-contempt by which to extinguish it.

(28) One given to envy has non-envy by which to extinguish it.

(29) One given to stinginess has non-stinginess by which to extinguish it.

(30) One given to deceit has non-deceit by which to extinguish it.

(31) One given to fraud has non-fraud by which to extinguish it.

(32) One given to obstinacy has non-obstinacy by which to extinguish it.

(33) One given to arrogance has non-arrogance by which to extinguish it.

(34) One given to being difficult to admonish has being easy to admonish by which to extinguish it.

(35) One given to making bad friends has making good friends by which to extinguish it.

(36) One given to negligence has vigilance by which to extinguish it.

(37) One given to faithlessness has faith by which to extinguish it.

(38) One given to lack of moral dignity has moral dignity by which to extinguish it.

(39) One given to lack of moral dread has moral dread by which to

extinguish it.

(40) One given to little learning has great learning by which to extinguish it.

(41) One given to laziness has the arousal of energy by which to extinguish it.

(42) One given to unmindfulness has the establishment of mindfulness by which to extinguish it.

(43) One given to lack of wisdom has the acquisition of wisdom by which to extinguish it.

(44) One given to adhering to his own views, holding on to them tenaciously and relinquishing them with difficulty, has non-adherence to his own views, not holding on to them tenaciously and relinquishing them easily, by which to extinguish it.

(Conclusion)

“Thus, O Cunda, the course of effacement has been taught by me, the course of arousing the mind has been taught by me, the course of avoidance has been taught by me, the course leading upwards has been taught by me, and the course of extinguishing has been taught by me. Whatever should be done, O Cunda, by a teacher for his disciples, desiring their welfare, having pity for them, that has been done for you by me, out of compassion. These are the feet of trees, O Cunda, these are empty huts. Meditate, O Cunda, do not be negligent, lest you regret it later. This is our instructions to you.”

That is what the Auspicious One said. The venerable Mahācunda was satisfied and delighted in the Auspicious One’s words.